# The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Reuters

The **International Energy Agency** will release a record stock of oil from its emergency reserves to counter oil-price volatility. The global forecaster's 32 members "unanimously agreed" to release 400m barrels onto the market, said Fatih Birol, the IEA's head, but did not specify the daily volumes. Iran's blocking of the Strait of Hormuz has curtailed global supply by roughly 20m barrels a day.

**Donald Trump** said the Iran war would end "soon" as there was "practically nothing left to target", in comments to Axios, a news site. America's armed forces said it had by now conducted airstrikes on more than 5,500 targets inside Iran. Earlier the Pentagon claimed that America had "eliminated" 16 Iranian mine-planting boats. Iran said it would target American and Israeli financial interests in the Middle East.

**Iran's** police chief warned that anyone protesting against the regime would be treated "the way we treat the enemy". Despite encouragement from Mr Trump and Binyamin Netanyahu, reform-minded Iranians have not yet taken to the streets in great numbers during this American-Israeli campaign. They are unlikely to until the bombs stop dropping. Iran fired more missiles towards Israel and American facilities in Iraq and Qatar.

**America's** annual **inflation** rate was 2.4% in February. The rate, which remains unchanged from January and is the lowest since 2021, was in line with forecasts. The data was gathered before the global surge in energy prices, which would only begin to appear in next month's data—but may inform the Federal Reserve's rate decision next week.

**Oracle** reported revenues of $17.2bn in the first quarter—a 22% rise on the same period a year ago—beating analysts' expectations. The software giant has been investing in cloud-computing infrastructure to compete with Amazon and Microsoft. Oracle raised its revenue forecast for next year to $90bn, citing strong demand for its cloud services, which are used to train AI; its share price rose by 9% in after-hours trading.

**Meta** said it would acquire **Moltbook**, a no-humans-allowed social network for AI agents that launched in January and went viral. It did not disclose the price. As part of the deal Meta will hire Moltbook's two co-founders to work at its "superintelligence labs", the technology giant's AI unit. It has spent hundreds of millions of dollars poaching researchers from rivals.

**Britain's** House of Lords voted to end its hereditary peerages. The centuries-old tradition, which allowed members with inherited titles to sit and vote in the upper house of parliament, had been mostly abolished in 1999 under a previous Labour government. The bill ends a long tussle to remove the remaining 92 hereditary peers; some will be granted life peerages instead.

**Figure of the day:** 56, the total number of ethnicities in China, of which 55 are getting squashed. Read our story.

Photograph: Getty Images

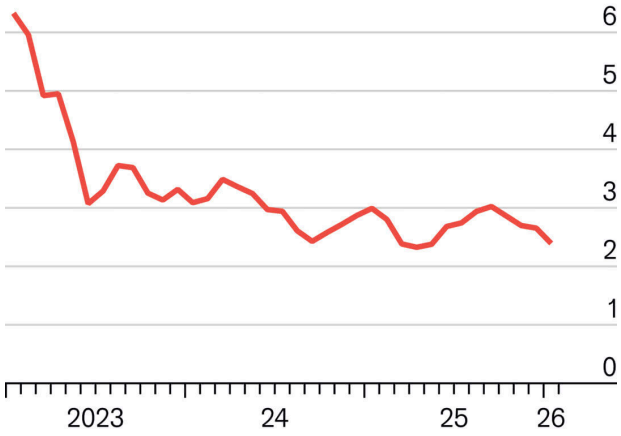
# War in Iran torpedoes America's progress on inflation

For a few months American inflation appeared to be cooling. By the start of 2026 Donald Trump's tariffs had in large part passed through to higher prices. Meanwhile, high interest rates took some heat out of the jobs market. The "affordability crisis" became a story of already-high prices, rather than still-rising ones.

But Mr Trump's attack on Iran triggered retaliatory strikes that blocked the Strait of Hormuz, a vital shipping lane. The benchmark West Texas Intermediate oil price surged by about 75%, peaking at around $120 per barrel before falling to around $85—still a quarter higher than before the war. Inflation figures for February, to be published on Wednesday, will not reflect the effects of the conflict. Forecasters think the annual price rise was 2.4%, above the Federal Reserve's 2% target but not by much. The real question will be what the numbers for March show and how much damage Operation "Epic Fury" has done to America's progress in reducing inflation.

## False dawn?

**United States, consumer price index, % increase on a year earlier**




Sources: BLS; BEA

Photograph: Kenny Holston/The New York Times/Redux/eyevine

## Anthropic takes the Trump administration to court

A legal battle over who controls the world's most important technology is proceeding rapidly. On Tuesday representatives from Anthropic, an artificial-intelligence lab, urged a federal court to fast-track its lawsuits against America's Department of War, which the company says could cost it billions in revenue this year.

The spat has been ugly. On February 26th Anthropic refused to alter its contract with the Pentagon over fears its technology might be used for mass surveillance of Americans or in fully autonomous weapons. A week later Anthropic became the first American company to be designated a supply-chain risk by the government, barring its models from defence projects. On Monday, Anthropic said that it was suing the DOW. The company has some sympathy among Silicon Valley's AI developers: more than 30 employees from Google and OpenAI, two rival AI giants, have filed an "amicus" brief in support. The first hearing has been brought forward to March 24th.

Photograph: Jan Woitas/dpa

## Europe’s plan to avert an energy crisis

On Wednesday Ursula von der Leyen, the president of the European Commission, is taking part in a parliamentary debate about the war in the Gulf and its consequences. Among them are the sharp swings in oil prices and markets instability. Ms von der Leyen has called it a “stark reminder” of the vulnerabilities created by Europe’s dependence on fossil fuels.

Some European governments are weighing tax cuts on fuel; others want to cut environmental measures. (Viktor Orban, Hungary’s prime minister and an ally of the Kremlin, has called on the EU to lift its sanctions on Russian energy.) The arrival of spring and less demand for heating—plus measures taken to diversify supply after Russia invaded Ukraine in 2022—mean the continent is unlikely to run out of gas, but Europeans may still feel some financial pain. Leaders of the EU’s 27 member states will meet next week to discuss how to prevent a sharp rise in bills from hobbling its still-fragile economy.

Photograph: Bridgeman Images

## The memory of Fukushima

On Wednesday Japan observes the 15th anniversary of the deadly earthquake that triggered the worst nuclear disaster since Chernobyl. A tsunami killed almost 20,000 people across the north of the country and triggered a meltdown at a nuclear power plant in Fukushima. The nuclear disaster displaced about 160,000 people from the surrounding area. With trust in nuclear power shattered, Japan closed all 54 of its remaining reactors.

Public opinion has since shifted. In 2013, a poll by *Asahi Shimbun*, a newspaper, showed that 58% of respondents were opposed to restarting the plants, while only 28% supported it; by 2023, support outnumbered opposition for the first time, as energy bills soared during the Ukraine war.

Wednesday's commemoration will therefore be held amid a striking policy reversal. Having pledged to reduce nuclear dependence after Fukushima, Japan's newly empowered government is now pursuing "maximum utilisation". In February TEPCO—the operator responsible for the Fukushima disaster—restarted the world's largest power station, on Japan's west coast.

Photograph: Reuters

# The Norwegian underdog of European football

The 16 clubs that remain in the Champions League are a roll call of Europe’s elite squads. They include six from the money-soaked Premier League in Britain, three from Spain, Germany’s Bayern Munich and France’s Paris Saint-Germain, the defending champions.

Yet the name that stands out is Bodo/Glimt of Norway, whose 8,200-capacity home stadium is just inside the Arctic Circle. The club has won Norway’s Eliteserien league in four of the past six years. The minnow is now going after Europe’s big fish. Last season Bodo/Glimt reached the semi-finals of the Europa League, a level down from the Champions League. So far in the Champions League, they have defeated Atletico Madrid and Manchester City, two heavyweights, and knocked out Inter Milan, last year’s finalists, in the play-off round. If they win the first leg against Sporting Lisbon, one of the weaker teams in the tournament, on Wednesday, they could continue their improbable run into the quarter finals.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

# Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to [email protected]. We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

**Wednesday:** What was the biggest hit by DNCE, a rock band whose lead singer was Joe Jonas?

**Tuesday**: Which William Somerset Maugham novel features a cholera epidemic in China?

*Fear cannot be banished, but it can be calm and without panic; it can be mitigated by reason and evaluation.*

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***Vannevar Bush***